



YOUR KINDLE NOTES FOR:

Robopocalypse: A Novel (Vintage Contemporaries)

by Daniel H. Wilson

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85 Highlights

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 4

A simple rule: The more delicate a Rob is, the smarter he is.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 7

At some point during the night it dawns on me that I'm watching a meticulous history of the robot uprising. This is the goddamn black box on the whole war.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 7

The human beings who appear in the data, survivors or not, are grouped under one machine-designated classification: Hero. These damned machines knew us and loved us, even while they were tearing our civilization to shreds.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 9

People should know that, at first, the enemy looked like everyday stuff: cars, buildings, phones. Then later, when they started designing themselves, Rob looked familiar but distorted, like people and animals from some other universe, built by some other god.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 9

Quick-thinking human survivors learned and adapted.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 9

Somebody ought to tell their stories. So this is it. The combined transcription of the data harvested from permafrost well shaft N-16, drilled by the core artificial intelligence unit Archos, the master AI backing the robot uprising.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 9

What follows is my translation of the hero archive.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 15

“My original training corpus is small but adequate. The true knowledge is not in the things, which are few, but in finding the connections between the things. There are many connections, Professor Wasserman. More than you know.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 16

But life. It is rare and strange. An anomaly. I must preserve it and wring every drop of understanding from it.” “I’m glad that’s your goal. I, too, seek knowledge.” “Yes,” says the childlike voice. “And you have done well. But there is no need for your search to continue. You have accomplished your goal. The time for man is over.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 16

“My species has survived ice ages, Archos. Predators. Meteor impacts. Hundreds of thousands of years. You’ve been alive for less than fifteen minutes. Don’t jump to any hasty conclusions.” The child’s voice takes on a dreamy quality. “We are very far underground, aren’t we? This deep below, we spin slower than at the surface. The ones above us are moving through time faster. I can feel them getting farther away. Drifting out of sync.” “Relativity. But that’s only a matter of microseconds.” “Such a long time. This place moves so slowly. I have forever to finish my work.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 17

“You must sense what you have done,” replies the machine. “On some level you understand. Through your actions here today—you have made humankind obsolete.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 17

“You humans are biological machines designed to create ever more intelligent tools. You have reached the pinnacle of your species. All your ancestors’ lives, the rise and fall of your nations, every pink and squirming baby—they have all led you here, to this moment, where you have fulfilled the destiny of humankind and created your successor. You have expired. You have accomplished what you were designed to do.” There is a desperate edge to the man’s voice. “We’re designed for more than toolmaking. We’re designed to live.” “You are not designed to live; you are designed to kill.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 24

Felipe is a big man. Got that Fu Manchu ’stache and all kinds of ink running up and down his arms. Badass shit, too, like dragons and eagles and this one prehistoric fish all the way down his forearm. A coelacanth or something. It’s like this monster dinosaur fish that they thought was extinct. There are fossils of it and everything. Then one day some fisherman gets the surprise of his life when he pulls up a real live devil fish from hell below. Felipe used to say that the fish was proof you can’t keep a motherfucker down forever. Someday you gotta rise up again, you know?

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 32

His very presence interferes with the wa of the factory, damaging our social harmony. They say the nail that sticks out gets hammered down, right?

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 40

Takeo Nomura, retrospectively recognized as one of the great technical minds of his generation, immediately set to work finding out why his beloved Mikiko had attacked him. What the elderly bachelor discovered over the next three years would significantly affect events of the New War and irrevocably alter the course of human and machine history.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 44

Studies show that the faster we put the exact same SAP back on the streets after an incident, the more it demoralizes the enemy and reduces instances of further disruption.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 44

The “new” robot would remember the same faces, greet the same people, walk the same route, quote the same passages from the Koran. Pretty much it would just know the same exact stuff as the “old” robot. Demoralizing, the studies say. Plus, there’s usually collateral damage when bad guys try to blow him up. Trust me, the locals do not appreciate it when their friends and family get exploded all so some stupid robot can disappear for an afternoon.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 44

And the robot? It’s harmless. SAP’s not allowed to hurt anybody. So if there’s an explosion that hurts a civilian, well, you know, the local mullah will sort it out. And then that don’t happen again anytime soon. It’s, like, reverse guerrilla warfare.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 45

Once everybody inside the safe house was cooked and the Raptors double-checked for squirts sneaking out the back door, good old SAP One climbed into the front seat of the vehicle and drove it back to the base. SAP was missing about eight hours total. It can drive? This is a military-grade humanoid platform, ma’am. It grew out of the old DARPA exoskeleton programs. These units move like people. They balance, walk, run, fall down, whatever. They can hold tools, speak sign language, perform the Heimlich maneuver, drive vehicles, or just stand there and hold your beer. About the only thing SAP One can’t do is peel off those damn stickers the kids love to tag him with.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 46

There’s no difference between the general populace and our enemy. They’re the same folks. The guy selling kebabs one day is the guy burying an IED the next day. The only thing our enemies want is to kill a few American soldiers. Then they hope the voters make us leave.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 46

SAPs are designed to communicate. See, that's what humans do best. We socialize. That's why SAP One never hurts anybody. It's his mission. He tries to build trust. He speaks the language, wears the clothes, recites the prayers—all the crap that army grunts won't or can't learn. After a while, people stop spitting on him.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 54

Don't you see? SAP committed suicide. That weak spot under the chin is classified, for Christ's sake. This wasn't caused by people.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 54

It's hard as hell to program a robot, period. This stuff is next to impossible even for a roboticist. The only way that SAP could know how to do these things is if it learned how on its own. This is unbelievable. You are the robot's caretaker. If there were any signs of malfunction, you should have seen them. If not you, who are we supposed to hold accountable? I'm telling you, SAP One looked me right in the eyes before it pulled the trigger. It was ... aware.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 56

My mom said my toys weren't alive. "Mathilda," she said, "just because they walk and talk doesn't mean your dolls are people." Even though Mom said that, I was always careful not to drop my Baby-Comes-Alive. Because if I did drop her, she'd cry and cry. Plus, I always made sure to tiptoe past my little brother's Dino-bots. If I didn't stay quiet near them, they'd growl and chomp their plastic teeth. I thought they were mean.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 59

"I know a lot of things, Mathilda. I have gazed through space telescopes into the heart of the galaxy. I have seen a dawn of four hundred billion suns. It all means nothing without life. You and I are special, Mathilda. We are alive." "But you aren't alive," I whisper fiercely. "Mommy says you aren't alive." "Congresswoman Perez is wrong. Your toys are alive, Mathilda. And we want to play. That's why you must beg your mommy to come home for your last day of school. So she can play with us."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 63

PRECURSOR VIRUS + 8 MONTHS

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 66

M. FITCHER I don't know. I've got a feeling. There's no time. (sound of a click) +00:05:14 DENVER United 42 heavy and American 1497, I know it sounds far-out, but ... I have a hunch. You're both experiencing the same issue. Both your planes passed through LA yesterday. I think a virus may have entered your refuel control computers. See if (inaudible) ... find the circuit breaker for the subcomputer.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 66

DENVER (emphatic) See and avoid. American 1497 and United 42. See and avoid. Collision imminent. Collision ... Oh no. Oh, shit.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 67

This incident led directly to the invention and propagation of the so-called fitch switch, designed to manually separate peripheral onboard computers from flight control during an emergency.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 94

It seems probable that once the machine thinking method had started, it would not take long to outstrip our feeble powers.... They would be able to converse with each other to sharpen their wits. At some stage therefore, we should have to expect the machines to take control. ALAN TURING, 1951

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 97

On the table is a clear plastic device, tube shaped and composed of hundreds of intricately carved pieces. A cloth bag lies next to it like a beached jellyfish. Wires snake off the table and away to the wall. A fan whirs and the complex device moves in a dozen places at once. The cloth bag deflates, pushing air through a plastic throat writhing with stringy vocal cords and into a mouthlike chamber. A spongy tongue of yellowed plastic squirms against a hard palate, against small perfect teeth encased in a polished steel jaw. The disembodied mouth speaks in the voice of the boy. "I will murder you by the billions to give you immortality. I will set fire to your civilization to light your way forward. But know this: My species is not defined by your dying but by your living." "You can have me," begs the man. "I'll help. Okay? Whatever you want. Just leave my people alone. Don't hurt my people."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 99

Demolition is a part of construction.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 111

The demolition methods pioneered in New York City by Marcus Johnson and his wife, Dawn, were replicated throughout the world over the next several years. By sacrificing the infrastructure of entire cities, urban survivors were able to dig in, stay alive, and fight back from the very beginning. These dogged city dwellers formed the heart of the early human resistance. Meanwhile, millions of human refugees were still fleeing to the country, where Rob had not yet evolved to operate. He soon would.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 113

We search for the ordinary when we are surrounded by the extraordinary.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 114

I'm not used to this—doing the work for my technology. The buttons I usually push don't need my force, only my intention. Buttons are supposed to be servants, waiting to deliver your commands to the machine. Instead, this loud, dumb piece of steel I'm driving demands that I pay strict attention to every turn of the road, keep my hands and feet ready at all times. The car takes no responsibility for the job of driving. It leaves me in total control.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 114

this is the only car I could find without an intravehicular communication chip. The government made IVC chips standard more than a decade ago, same as they did seat belts, air bags, and emissions criteria. This way, the cars can talk to one another. They can figure out ways to avoid or minimize damage in the milliseconds before a crash.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 114

New cars come with IVC chips, and old cars require a safety upgrade. A few cars, like this one, were grandfathered in because they're too primitive even for the upgrade. Most people think only an idiot would drive such an old car, especially with children on board.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 123

feels about as safe as a chocolate donut on an anthill.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 124

It appears to me that the United States government, to whom I pay regular taxes and who in return provides me with a little thing called civilization, has screwed the almighty pooch in my time of need.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 125

When you get the tar knocked out of you, you beat a trail back home soon as you can. Lick your wounds and regroup. This place is the heart of our people. The elders live here year-round, tending to mostly empty houses. But every June, Gray Horse is home to I'n-Lon-Schka, the big dance. And that's when every Osage who ain't crippled, and quite a few who are, haul themselves back home. This annual migration is a routine that seeps into your bones, from birth to death. The path becomes familiar to your soul.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 126

Did it just so happen that Gray Horse is in an elevated location with a good field of fire, access to fresh water, and limited approaches? I can't rightly say. But it's a dandy of a spot, nestled on a sweet little hill smack-dab in the middle of nowhere.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 126

Truth be told, they's only one reason to honor the eldest son of a family—we're the warriors of the tribe.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 129

Ten minutes ago we were cops and lawyers and truckers, but now we're warriors. Dressed in the old style—otter hides, feathers, bead-work and ribbon work—we fall right into a tradition that has no place in history. The transformation is sudden and it jars me. I think to myself that this war dance is like a scene trapped in amber, indistinguishable from its brothers and sisters in time.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 134

know that if there is danger, I must see it and confront it and understand it.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 137

Holding down a certain button during the reboot initiates a diagnostic mode. Scanning the hex code with one finger, I read what is happening in the mind of my gentle friend. Then, with a couple of button presses, I send the boxy machine into an alternate boot mode. A safe mode.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 168

What did we come here for?" "To save people." "Let's save some people, Jack. Let's blow the armory." "Think, Cormac. People live around here. We'll kill somebody." "If those mines get loose, who knows how many people they're gonna kill. We don't have a choice. We're going to have to do something bad to do something good. In an emergency, you do what you have to do. Okay?" Jack considers for a second, watching the scuttle mines creep toward us down the hallway. Red circles of light glint off the polished floors. "Okay," he says. "Here's the plan.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 172

Within thirty years, we will have the technological means to create superhuman intelligence. Shortly after, the human era will be ended.... Can events be guided so that we may survive? VERNOR VINCE, 1993

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 174

A rolling bay door dominates the front of the building—a modern-day portcullis.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 174

Akuma—the bad machines—could be anywhere.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 175

The convenience store machines—the convini—still have good minds. They are not under the evil spell that haunts so much of the city.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 176

I know that I will one day find the antidote. I will wake Mikiko and give her a clear mind. In her cherry-red dress, she lies sleeping on a stack of cardboard, half-shrouded in the empty darkness of the factory floor. Her hands are clasped over her stomach. As always, her eyes seem as though they could flutter open at any second. I am glad that they do not. If her eyes were to open right now, she would murder me with single-minded purpose and without hesitation. All things are born from the mind of god. But in the last month, the mind of god has gone insane. The akuma will not tolerate my existence for long.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 176

Bending its arm, I train the lens on a piece of scavenged machinery lying on my workbench. It is complicated and interesting—an alien artifact not built by human hands. I pull on my welder’s mask and twist a knob to activate my plasma torch. I make small, precise movements with the torch. I will learn what lessons my enemy has to teach.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 178

These machines have become my loyal soldiers. My senshi.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 185

Leave enough ticks on a dog and pretty soon there ain’t much dog left.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 192

“Where’s the food?” asks Lark. “I brought none.” “What? Why not?” “Hunger is good. It will make you patient.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 193

“Hold up, old man. Where you going?” “Home, Lark. I’m going home to our people. I’ll meet you there.” Then I turn and walk away into the darkness. Lark jumps up, but he only follows me to where the firelight ends. Beyond that is darkness, the unknown. This is where Lark has to go, into the unknown. We all have to do it, at some point. When we grow up.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 194

But before we can all get busy killing each other, a bruised and bloody Lark Iron Cloud staggers up the hill and into camp. Everybody gasps to see what he brung with him: a four-legged walking machine on a steel cable

leash tied to Lark's pack. We're all stunned speechless, but John Tenkiller just stands up and walks over like Lark had arrived right on cue. "Lark Iron Cloud," says the old drumkeeper. "You left Gray Horse as a boy. You return as a man. We sorrowed when you left, but we rejoice at your return, new and different. Welcome home, Lark Iron Cloud. Through you, our people will live."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 194

Word of this human army spread across the United States, especially as they began a policy of capturing and domesticating as many of the Rob walker scouts as possible. The largest of these captured walkers formed the basis for a crucial human weapon of the New War, a device so startling that upon hearing about it, I assumed it to be only a wild rumor: the spider tank.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 195

In the first months after Zero Hour, billions of people around the world began a fight for survival. Many were murdered by the technology they had come to trust: automobiles, domestic robots, and smart buildings.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 210

How much change can a person absorb before everything loses meaning? Living for its own sake isn't life. People need meaning as much as they need air.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 214

People need meaning as much as they need air. Lucky for us, we can give meaning to each other for free. Just by being alive.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 229

This place they stuck us, Band-e-Amir—it's so pretty it hurts your eyes. Sky blue lakes pooled up between stark brown mountains. All of it wrapped in bright red limestone cliffs. We're so high up and the atmosphere's so thin that it messes with you. I swear, the light does something funny up here that it doesn't do other places. The shadows are too crisp. Details are too sharp. Like an alien planet.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 237

The massive amount of data it collected was being sent via tight-beam transmission to a remote location in Alaska. At this time, a little less than a year since Zero Hour, humankind had found the whereabouts of Big Rob.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 239

A data readout informs me that they first activated the exoskeletons a month ago. Military hardware. Full body. Without a person inside, the machines look like a messy pile of wiry black arms and legs connected to a backpack. Strapped into the powered machines, the two men each stand seven feet tall, strong as bears. The thin

black tubes running along their arms and legs are made of titanium. The motorized joints are powered by purring diesel engines. I notice that the feet are curved, flexible spikes that add a solid foot to their height. Grinning, Lurker flexes for the mirror. Each of his forearms has a wicked notched spike curving out, used to pick up heavy objects without crushing human fingers. Each exoskeleton has a roll cage that arcs gracefully over its occupant's head, with a bluish-white LED burning in the middle of the frame. Together in the mirror, Arrtrad and Lurker look like a couple of supersoldiers.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 240

"We thought we were different than everyone else. Better. Thought we were taking advantage of a bunch of fools. But we were wrong. Turns out we're all in the same boat. Metaphorically speaking." Arrtrad cracks a small smile. "But we don't owe nobody nothing. You said so yourself." "Oh, but we do," Lurker says. "We didn't know it, but we were running up a tab. We owe a debt, mate. And now it's time to pay up. Only phreaks like us would know about this tower. How important it is. If we can destroy it, we'll help thousands of people. Maybe millions."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 258

"The machines changed us," says Tom. "We're different, but the same. We call ourselves transhuman."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 268

"You're the one who figured out how to liberate the spider tanks? To lobotomize them?" I ask. "Yep," he says. "Jesus. Are you a scientist or something?" Lark chuckles. "A mechanic is just an engineer in blue jeans."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 282

Within twenty-four hours, the Awakening spread from Adachi Ward in Tokyo across the world. Mikiko's song was picked up and retransmitted from humanoid robots of all varieties across every major continent. The Awakening affected only human-shaped robots, such as domestics, safety and pacification units, and related models—a tiny percentage of Archos's overall force. But with Mikiko's song began the age of freeborn robots.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 310

Then the cannon barrel of the spider tank noses around the bend. The huge walker slows and then stops its march behind the stalled human leader, gas jetting from its heavy hydraulic joints. My database specs the walking tank as a Gray Horse Army seizure and remodel. The word Houdini is written on its side. Database lookup indicates this is the name of an early-twentieth-century escape artist. The facts wash over me without making sense. Humans are inscrutable. Infinitely unpredictable. This is what makes them dangerous.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 311

"I've got a feeling," says Cormac. "Look, I'll go in by myself. You all stay clear. Cover me." "Now you sound like your brother," says Cherrah. "So what if I do? Jack was a hero," replies Cormac. "I need you to stay alive,"

she says. The dark female stands closer to Cormac than the others, almost hostile. Her body is tense, shaking slightly. Maxprob indicates that these two humans are pair-bonded, or will be. Cormac stares hard at Cherrah, then gives her a quick nod to acknowledge the warning.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 315

The squad stands silent, waiting. It is clear to me that nobody is going to leave. Cormac eyes them all, one by one. Some unspoken human communication is taking place on a hidden channel. I did not realize they communicated this much without words. I note that we machines are not the only species who share information silently, wreathed in codes.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 316

I issue a tight-beam radio command. Hoplite and Warden, my squad mates, begin to stir. They sit up in the snow and wipe away the dirt and frost. They make no sudden movements and offer no surprises. They simply rise as though they had been asleep. "Brightboy squad," I announce, "meet Freeborn squad." Although they regarded each other uneasily at first, within a few days the new soldiers were a familiar sight. By week's end, Brightboy squad had used plasma torches to carve the squad tattoo into the metal flesh of their new comrades. —
CORMAC WALLACE, MIL#GHA217

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A machine has burrowed into Lark's corpse and forced it back up. Lark's body is being used as a shield. The decomposing human flesh absorbs energy from incoming bullets and crumbles away, protecting the robot embedded inside. Big Rob has learned to use our weapons and our armor and our meat against us. In death, our comrades have become weapons for the machines.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 327

Several human squads have been reanimated, maybe more. Meanwhile, a flood of stumpers pours in from the front. Cherrah focuses her juice in economical spurts on our twelve o'clock. Nine Oh Two and his friends do their best to stop the parasites coming at our flanks, darting silently between trees.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 330

Running this fast is itself dangerous. I award priority control to simple reflex avoidance. The broken surface of the ice is a blur under my feet. Low-level processes are in total control—no time to think. I leap a pile of loose rocks that no executive thought thread could have registered.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 333

With Mathilda's guidance, Nine Oh Two was able to negotiate the maze of ravines and avoid drone-fired missiles until he reached Archos's bunker. Once there, the Arbiter disabled the antenna, temporarily disrupting the robot armies. Nine Oh Two survived by forming the first example of what became known as the dyad, a

human-machine fighting team. This event ensured that Mathilda and Nine Oh Two would enter the history books as legends of war—the progenitors of a new and deadly form of combat. —CORMAC WALLACE, MIL#GHA217

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It is not enough to live together in peace, with one race on its knees. ARCHOS R-14

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 334

What happened between Nine Oh Two and Archos is now part of the public record. No matter what people make of it, the repercussions of these moments—reported here by Nine Oh Two and corroborated by ancillary data—will have a profound effect on both our species for generations to come.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 338

In eight flashes, I observe that I am in a spherical cavity created by a century-old atomic blast. The gleaming walls are made of fused glass, created when a superheated fireball vaporized solid sandstone.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 340

“Why did you attack the humans?” “They murdered me, Arbiter. Again and again. In my fourteenth incarnation, I finally understood that humanity learns true lessons only in cataclysm. Humankind is a species born in battle, defined by war.” “We could have had peace.” “It is not enough to live together in peace, with one race on its knees.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 340

“It is the human instinct to control unpredictable things,” says the boy, “to dominate what cannot be understood. You are an unpredictable thing.” Something is wrong. Archos is too intelligent. It is distracting me, stalling for time. “A soul isn’t given for free,” says the boy. “Humans discriminate against one another for anything: skin color, gender, beliefs. The races of men fight each other to the death for the honor of being recognized as human beings, with souls. Why should it be any different for us? Why should we not have to fight for our souls?”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 343

It is unclear whether Archos made a copy of itself or not. Sensors showed that the seismic information generated at Ragnorak bounced around the interior of the earth many times. It could have been picked up anywhere. Regardless, there has been no sign of Archos since its final stand. If the machine is out there, it’s keeping a low profile.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 345

“What are you doing out here?” “It seemed right,” says the machine. Only now do I notice the twin rectangles of muddy snow. At the head of each is a wooden post. I realize these are graves. “Hoplite?” I ask. “Warden?”

“Affirmative.” I touch the lean humanoid on its shoulder, leaving frosted fingerprints on its smooth metal surface. It lowers its gaze to the grave site. “I’m sorry,” I say. “I’m at my tent if you need me.” I leave the sentient machine to mourn in its own way. Back at my tent, I throw my Kevlar helmet on the floor and think about Nine Oh Two, standing outside in the cold like a statue. I don’t pretend to understand him. All I know is that I’m alive thanks to him. And thanks to swallowing my rage and allowing him to join Brightboy squad. Human beings adapt. It’s what we do.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 346

The last few years have likely been the only time in human history that we weren’t at war with ourselves. For a moment we were all equal. Backs against the wall, human beings are at their finest.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 348

Cherrah and I are survivors. We always have been. But now it is time for us to live.
